Barefoot Boy with Cheek?

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The words reach Tony but fail to register, because in his imagination he is once again the hero about to do battle with the forces of evil.

Though the young boy has grown into a man now, he still lives partly in his imagination. As a youngster in Boston, from a better than ordinary social and economic background, Tony Perkins fashioned for himself a romantic world to liven an otherwise well-regulated existence. As a film star he is still playing the same game.

Because he is really what he seems to be—a nice enough, ordinary young fellow—and because he feels that as an actor he should be more colorful, Tony has been working overtime at it.

Sometimes his attempts at achieving color border on the ridiculous. During the filming of "Friendly Persuasion" he used to eat regularly at Googie's, a small coffee shop next door to Schwab's in Hollywood. He told new acquaintances there that he worked in an airplane factory. "I thought they'd like me better if they didn't think I was another actor in competition with them," he says by way of explanation.

More likely, Tony hoped that when they did learn he was starring in a big film, they would be amazed at his modesty. He was also hoping that the discovery of who he really was would have some dramatic impact.

Tony was playing a game much as Jimmy Dean did the day he drove up to the "Giant" location in Marfa, Texas. Finding a new gateman on the job, Dean tried to get in without announcing himself as a star of the film. In blue jeans and leather jacket, with his old junk car, Jimmy hardly looked like an actor, and he knew it.

But he wanted to test the policeman to see if the man knew who he was; just as Tony was probably testing the new acquaintances to see if they had heard of him.

Much of Tony's eccentric behavior is likened to Jimmy's and is equally studied. For example, Tony is reported to have walked out of his apartment many times barefoot, supposedly having forgotten to put on his shoes.

Unquestionably, it must take a certain amount of cheek to carry off this kind of activity. In Tony's case, however, much of the odd behavior is reported rather than seen. And the reporter is invariably Tony, who tells interviewers how he walked out of the house barefoot.

To a large extent these stories have been successful, but a few have backfired. For example, in a recent *Life* magazine story, much was made of the fact that Tony hitchhiked daily to Paramount Studios from his apartment, and that he cooked his meals on a hot plate in his room. As a matter of fact, he may have hitchhiked to Paramount once for the record, but it's certain that he didn't do it as a daily habit. As for cooking in his room, the management at Tony's apartment was miffed at the story because cooking in nonhousekeeping rooms is frowned upon. When they were told that it was all for publicity, no serious damage was sustained.

Some of the stories have the ring of familiarity. Tony once said he would "rather be called a 'young' anything than 'another young' anything." Marlon Brando said it earlier, and the late Humphrey Bogart said it before Marlon.

Sometimes it's not that Tony tells deliberate untruths about himself, but that he allows you to assume things. He cleverly throws out the bait, lets the listener nibble, and then plays out the line. Here's a for-instance: During a recent interview Tony said something about going on his bike to a party. The interviewer knew that Tony had a date, so he asked if she was on the bike, too. Tony's answer was merely a smile. The reporter assumed that the girl went on the bike—which she didn't—but the story spread.

To an interviewer Tony has a chameleon-like quality, changing protective coloration to accommodate the questions. He can shift easily from shy ingenuousness to long thoughtful silences broken by terse phrases or half sentences. With his head lowered he will look up at you, a perplexing, reflective look on his face. You want to know everything about him; you sense the shifting emotions, the racing and twisting thoughts. Although you often suspect that he is telling a half-truth or acting boastfully modest, you go along with him because, in a word, Tony has charm.

Everyone who comes in contact with Tony is aware of this charm, including the housekeeper at the Chateau Marmont where he now lives. Norma Moore, one of Tony's Hollywood dates, considers him one of the most charming men she has ever met—and one of the most unpredictable. The charm which he turns on and off at will enables him to keep his head above the flood of stories which he has caused to circulate about himself.

One day while I was talking with Tony at Paramount, Autumn Russell, a very pretty contract player, joined us. The change in Tony was remarkable. It was almost as though someone had told him that the cameras were grinding, and he suddenly flashed charm from every pore. His stories became more elaborate. His own importance in them increased. He was doing as any man would—trying to impress a pretty girl.

But, more important, Tony knew Autumn was married, so he had no intention of asking her for a date. Yet she represented an interested audience. Like many young actors, Tony only needs one other person and he's on-stage. If the other person happens to be a pretty female, so much the better.

With all this, Tony can be far more businesslike in an interview than stars many years his senior. During a talk with me for this story, he asked if I had brought a tape recorder along. When I said no, he seemed disappointed. I asked why.

"With a tape recorder there would be no chance of being misquoted," he said.

I explained that I was going to take comprehensive notes. He seemed pleased. "I get nervous when people don't take notes," he said.

The interview was conducted at Lucey's restaurant across the street from Paramount. Tony, who doesn't drink or smoke, ordered a light supper and told me how he came to be an actor.

He was born twenty-four years ago on Twenty-Third Street in New York. His father was Osgood Perkins, a matinee idol of the Twenties; his mother was a Wellesley College graduate and a socialite. The Perkins had been married ten years before Tony was born. He was their only child.

Osgood Perkins died when Tony was five, and Tony says he has no memories of him. Following her husband's death Tony's mother moved with him to Brookline, Massachusetts.

Until this time, Tony spoke mostly French as he had been raised by a French governess.

As a child Tony was considered something of a hell-raiser. He fought a lot with other children. His favorite game was to stuff an old suit of clothes with rags and blankets and throw it in front of passing cars. "I was threatened with reform school many times as a kid," Tony recalls with satisfaction. "I guess it's a miracle I never got in real trouble."

Tony's first ambition was to be a lifeguard, followed by an overwhelming wish to be an actor. Perhaps hours spent probing over his father's old scrapbooks had something to do with that. In high school Tony appeared in all of the school plays.

Since Osgood Perkins had gone to Harvard, Tony was enrolled at Browne and Nichols, a preparatory school for Harvard. He did not cause much of a flurry in academic circles. In fact, the only high school subject in which Tony excelled was French, which he spoke fluently, thanks to his childhood training. But he kept his knowledge of the language a secret and progressed normally with his class "That way I was sure of good grades in at least one subject," he recalled.

"Schoolteachers," he added with a grin, "like to think I'm a boy who needs mothering. That's how I got through high school, and I guess that's my appeal now to moviegoers."

His appeal to moviegoers is certainly a strong one, maternal or otherwise. But if playing the little boy was enough to get Tony through school, it was not enough, apparently, to get him into college. He was the first student in the history of Browne and Nichols who was not allowed to take the Harvard entrance examinations because his marks were so low.

After leaving prep school he took odd courses, did summer stock (including "Years Ago," a Ruth Gordon play) and passed some time at Rollins College in Florida. Eventually he wound up in New York's Columbia University taking extension courses.

It was during his stay at Columbia that Tony heard M-G-M had bought "Years Ago" and planned to film it under the title, "The Actress." On a hunch he hitchhiked to the coast and said he'd like to test for the part.

He was signed. After five weeks "The Actress" was finished and Tony went back to New York. He made sure he was in New York when the picture was released. But no one seemed impressed with it.

Then Tony went for an interview with Otto Preminger for the part of Joseph, opposite Rita Hayworth, in Columbia's "Joseph and His Brethren." He didn't make it. Mr. Preminger took one look at him and said, "I'm sorry, Mr. Perkins, you won't do. We're looking for Old Testament faces. You have a New Testament face."

With his New Testament face Tony went to see Elia Kazan for the lead in "East of Eden." He ended up with a Broadway role in "Tea and Sympathy."

"I almost didn't take the 'Tea' part because I didn't think I was good enough to do it," Tony recalled. "But then I figured that if Kazan thought I was good enough, I must be."

Later in the interview, Tony told me that he had expected to get the "Tea" role because he was "equipped to play it."

"My success has been a sort of chain reaction," he said. "It started with summer stock, then 'Years Ago,' the film and some good TV parts. Then came 'Friendly Persuasion.' I haven't been out of work for more than a week in years. I guess